

Q&A: Resistance, Rebirth and Moral Justice, What Suffers, Mindfulness Apps, Spiritual Attainments

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 48:22

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sambhasambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So there's one or two questions here which are worth just answering because we're in the midst of meditation.

The best way to deal with resistance towards the practice is to just keep practicing. It's as simple as that. When you get that sense of not wanting to do it at any time, you have to be careful not to be overpowered by it, not to associate with it, not to identify with it. So immediately you have to go into that position of "there is resistance," and then of course you sit and the very resistance is your object of meditation. You have to sit with it, and everything is screaming to get up and do something else, but you just stay there with it and you wait and wait and wait until it disappears.

Now, you might not have time to do that. No problem. You have to get up and get on with daily life. And then you come back for your next session, your next two-hour evening session, and there's lots of resistance. But you say to yourself, "Now there's resistance." And you sit down and you sit with the resistance. Feel it, feel it. And of course, when the resistance goes — if you can stay to the very end of it, the very end of the resistance — it disappears, it's gone. And then suddenly arises the opposite, the desire to do the meditation.

I remember on one occasion when I came back from Burma. To my surprise, when I was really going for it — but I remember coming back, and to my surprise, I had this tremendous resistance. Didn't want to sit at all. And that's what I did. I thought, well, this is just another mental state. And eventually it passed.

So with all these negative mental states, it's just making them an object, not identifying with it. "I have resistance" — "There is resistance to meditation." And then you just sit with it. If you can only handle five minutes, you've handled five minutes before you get up and run for it. And the more you do it, the more you are not reacting to that sense of not wanting to do something. And eventually, as I say, it'll pass like everything else passes.

Why should resistance come? There could be a multitude of reasons. You might have come to a point where you've done lots of meditation and nothing's happened and you wonder what's the point. But there

might just be a transposition of aversion onto the meditation. Remember, aversion and these negative states — well, even good states — they're not attached to the object that they're presenting. They are themselves an attitude that's locked into the heart. So we have, you might say, a balloon of aversion, and it can get averse to anything at any time for whatever reason it wants. And it might just be that as aversion comes up, it just grabs hold of meditation. It becomes an averse state. So the object of aversion, the object of fear, is a metaphor, it's a symbol for the actual attitude that's caught up inside us.

Once you've sussed that out, then of course it's not so easy to get caught up in it. If you think that the meditation is making you resistant, then of course you wouldn't meditate. If you thought the meditation itself was creating the sense of aversion, then of course you'd have to stop it because you'd say to yourself, "Well this is no good, it's making me feel averse." But if you recognize that it's the aversion that's come up first, looking for an object to be averse to, then you don't blame the meditation. You blame the aversion. Of course, we're not in the blame game, but even so.

And then you sit with it, and to your surprise — to my surprise — it completely disappears. Now that doesn't mean to say that it never comes back. No, it comes back, but this time you're not fooled by it. You just know there is aversion. It's just part of the course really, aversion to the practice.

What would it mean for one's practice if one believes in reincarnation? Would it be different? Reincarnation, or as Buddhism would have it, rebirth. Rebirth stresses the fact that it's not the same person who's being reincarnated. So you see that even in this life. You're not the same as you were when you were three years old. So there's been a rebirthing throughout this life until we've come to this sorry state.

So, does it make a difference? Well, it makes a difference in this sense that it would suggest some sort of moral justice. If you thought that this was the only life that you had and you could get away with it, then why not? Because there would be no further consequence.

Now, what happens to us from the outside very rarely is the direct consequence of an action because when you do something in the world it reverberates, doesn't it? It goes out into that matrix and when it comes back to you it comes back to you through a person or indeed through nature.

So, for instance, if you're foolish enough to stand under a tree when there's thunder and lightning and you happen to be blown up by a thunderbolt, that isn't because in the past life you electrocuted people to death. It's because you happen to be stupid to stand under a tree. So there's some sort of mismatch there. You think, well, I was only stupid. I didn't expect to be blown to bits. So you never know the consequence of an action because you're entering into a matrix of relationships.

So it is with people. You might say something which is just mildly making fun of somebody. A mild little sarcastic quip. But the other person's mortally wounded and goes about trying to destroy your life in order to regain their sense of self-respect. So there's no justice on that level that I can personally see. And even

in a future life, if something were to happen in a future life, again, you're into a matrix, you're into a fulsome relationship with the world around you. And a lot of it we just have to accept. You're born here into this society and this is the consequence.

However, internally something else is going on because internally is the way that you are experiencing yourself all the time, and you're experiencing yourself physically and emotionally and mentally — your thoughts etc. Now when we do something, it doesn't matter whether it's an act of speech or whatever, it goes into this internal matrix.

And again you don't know the effect of it because of, say, a person's past history where they have a store of shame — I'm thinking of a particular case and I can't remember the name — a store of shame within the person. And it's all been suppressed, it's all been repressed, it's all been down there, completely unaware of it. And then something happens where they lose face in close company or whatever, publicly, and they can't handle it. And they commit suicide. So you don't know the effect of an action.

But in the general, we can say that when we do something which is beneficial, morally good, etc., it has a beneficial good effect. And if it's the opposite, it'll have sorry effects. But at some point, there has to be some resolution. And you can't do it in one lifetime, it seems. You can't do it in one. There's so much gunge that you just can't get rid of it in one lifetime.

Even the Buddha is said to have lived many lifetimes in order to build up these qualities that would allow him to come into this life. And when he came into the life, he wouldn't have been completely pure. Mara was still after him. He still had all sorts of naughty thoughts. And then it was only through the process of purification that he was able to put an end to all those wrong desires.

So, from a point of view of this moral justice, there has to be some sort of resolution. And what the rebirth process suggests is that as you become aware of the suffering you're causing yourself and the catalyst that you are to other people's suffering — remember, we don't cause other people to suffer internally, we can make them suffer externally, you can physically hurt somebody, but the reaction that's going on in the person is always their own specific property.

Now that becomes obvious in Buddhist understanding because if somebody else causes the suffering in me then obviously my full liberation from suffering will only happen when I've got rid of you. So once you recognize that that isn't what the Buddha's teaching, because he himself was fully liberated, and people continued to upset him — whether he was upset or not, but definitely did things that weren't pleasant. They shouted at him, they called him all sorts of names, and one of his own disciples tried to kill him, if we're to believe it, Devadatta. He set the elephant on him and rolled a boulder down, which hurt his big toe, it seems.

So there has to be some sort of resolution and that takes time and that's the process of rebirth. So every time you are reborn from day to day, from moment to moment, you carry this baggage, you carry this

stuff from the past that you've created. And through the meditation, through right understanding etc., you begin to work at it, undermining it, not piling more on, or at least not piling so much on, that it undoes the work you did yesterday. I mean, that's normally the path that we're on. We clear a bit, we clear a lot, and then we dump a little bit back on. So it goes up and down. But eventually, hopefully, we can see an upward movement towards betterment.

So, there's a sort of moral justice in the sense that when we do harm, we do harm to ourselves. We can just do harm to ourselves and we can heal it. We can heal it over a long period of time.

Now it also makes sense from the point of view of the Buddha within. So it also connects with the whole idea of transcendence. Now something in us is not part of this psychophysical organism. It's something that is beyond it and yet within it. In it but not of it, no matter how you express it. And somehow, it's the one that's suffering.

When you have something like a pain in the knee, is the knee suffering? No. Something else is suffering. When you have a foul emotion, some anxiety that comes up, the anxiety isn't suffering. The something that suffers the anxiety is reacting to it. And so there's always something other which is the one who knows, the one who's aware, the one who's in touch with, the one who feels.

And that becomes obvious to us when we sit in meditation and we've plonked ourselves up on this observation post within ourselves. So everything is something that we're looking at. Normally speaking, your daily life, we dive in straight away. So if irritation comes up, you become the irritation. If you're depressed, "I am depressed." But here in meditation, we're learning that there can be all this stuff going on, but somehow you've retreated your sense of self back onto this perch.

Now, it must be this very same thing that is suffering from the delusion and has caused all this problem in the first place. And the whole process is for it to decide or for it to understand how it's done this and to come out of its own misery. It seems a bit odd, but the Buddha within is what's suffering. It's the one that actually is feeling and knowing and is in a state of delusion.

As we come out of that delusion, obviously we're changing our relationship to this organism, this being, this human being, this human beingness. And in that process of changing our relationship, there's an allowing of the organism to heal itself. So there we are. We pull back into ourselves. We found this sacred place, you might call it, this cave, this hideout, and we're looking and we're feeling, and the heart feels it has permission to release its turbulences. And to our surprise, or at least to our benefit, we find that when the heart releases its turbulence, it's actually healing itself. All these inner turbulences are getting less and less and less.

So it's only from the point of view of some sort of ethical justice that — in fact, because all this has been created out of a sense of ignorance, which was not culpable, it was an understandable mistake — you're born as this little bleating baby. You haven't a clue who you are and you make the big mistake of thinking

that, well, this is me. And that's continuing throughout our lives. So it's a delusion for which we're not culpable. We're not to be blamed for it. And through the process of insight, this very Buddha within, this *Satipaṇṇā*, becomes to recognize its own qualities. But by the time it gets to that, it's created this huge mess. So somehow the mess has to have time to liberate itself. The heart has to have time to liberate its problems.

So all that obviously is going to take a bit more than one lifetime. So the whole idea of rebirth fits in with the idea of transcendence. Otherwise it doesn't make sense.

So if you don't believe any of that, or at least if you put a brake on that and say, "Well, no, it's all rubbish," then that's fine, but then you're working for a different reason. You're now really just trying to get rid of the suffering within yourself. I'm trying to just get rid of my suffering and trying to, the best I can, over the period of time I've got, which now is quite short, is about finding an accommodation with life.

Now that's fine, but like I said this morning, this would be toning down or downscaling the Buddha's teachings to a psychotherapy. And there's benefit in that. There's benefit in that. And it might be that when you die, you suddenly find yourself standing next to your body and you think, "Oh, that was a mistake. I'll have to get reborn." So that may happen and of course it may not.

So it's for every individual really to work out their reasons for practice and to see the benefits of it. So the Buddha is quite clear. He says whether you believe in rebirth or not is immaterial because the Dharma has its benefits right here in daily practice. Remember in his day there were people who were also materialists. Didn't believe any of that stuff.

So I always think it's best to put these things on a back burner, really, just in case. Even if you were a climate change denier, it might be intelligent to behave as if there was. At least then you wouldn't be blamed. I think it was Pascal, wasn't it? What was it called? Pascal's wager. He said, "Well, there may be a God and there may not, but it might be intelligent to work as if there was God, just in case." So it might be worth our while, even if there's not that confidence in it, to work as if there were rebirth and as if there were transcendence, that's all. It can't do you any harm.

There's a little question here about mindfulness apps and stuff. And Headspace. Come on. They seem to be very useful. We're on one. Sadi Panya's got one on Insight Timer, which is a way for people doing this practice to connect with each other. I don't quite know how it works, but I think you've got a list of people and it tells you how much meditation you've done. So you're supposed to look at it and think, "He's done two hours, damn it. I'd better up my game here." It's a way of people communicating because the people involved with Sadi Panya anyway live all over the place.

The actual group that's around Satipanya itself, within travelling distance, which is about 15 miles, is very small. The population is very low. It would be a bit more substantial, I think, if I was closer to a conurbation, close to Birmingham or something. So how do you get that feeling of being part of something

and the support that you might get from that? So for us it's Insight Timer seems to be one way that people — I feel I think it's about 20 odd have joined it. So feel free, Insight Timer.

These other ones, I mean, I've had a quick glance at them and they seem to be all right. I mean, Headspace was actually created by a man who was a monk for quite a long while and then came back and wondered how he could spread it in more general ways.

I think it brings in \$100 million a year. So there's another very good reason for trying to create one of these. I'm not being cynical.

So with all these apps, it's up to us, isn't it, to use it to our benefit, to see if it works for us. It's asking: is this the way that mindfulness is going to go mainstream? Well, I don't think so, because eventually people gravitate towards a teacher, don't they? They gravitate towards a centre. I mean, they might use these things just to keep in contact or to create a group, a virtual group. But there has to be some basis, I think, in some real relationship, some real contact with somebody. At least that's how I would personally feel.

Just going back on this business of believing or putting trust in reincarnation and all that, there was an occasion when I was on a train down to Brighton, and some rugby fans got on. This man sat opposite me—a little bit tipsy—and he said, "Are you a Buddhist monk?" I said, "Yes, I am." He said, "Well, I don't believe in reincarnation." I said, "Do you know by your personal experience whether there is life after death or not?" And he said, "No." I said, "Well, why come to a conclusion?" And his mate said, "Yeah, why come to a conclusion?" Classic conversation. I loved it. I don't know whether he opened the possibility of it, but it was an interesting little conversation.

So the rest of it we can answer more over the weekend. There's one here about stream entry: how skillful is it to strive for it?

When the Mahāsi Sayadaw actually started teaching, he seems to have had very good results. Even the teenagers were especially open to this sort of practice and were seemingly very successful. Now we're going back to the 50s, where there wasn't the internet and life was very simple, very pure you might say. And the Burmese society then, as perhaps not so much recently, was very religious—I mean incredibly religious, as you might think of the Christian medieval ages. It was very religious. So the whole atmosphere of the society was about practice, about doing the practice.

When he began teaching in the 50s—they started the centre in 48, 49 or something—there was a lot of success and he used to give out certificates. There's a book on this, by the way: *The History of the Mahāsi Centre*. And it says in the book—I'm paraphrasing—that those people who had these certificates, of course they didn't actually stick them on their chests, but they would wander around with that sort of superior air of someone who had achieved stream entry and would look down upon these poor meditators sweating away on the floor. So I think he stopped that. They don't do that anymore because of the enormous conceit that can arise.

Normally speaking, things like—in the monastic life anyway—things like stream entry and all that sort of stuff is really kept quite between you and the teacher. The teacher may tell another teacher, but it's never something that's bandied about. A monk or a nun will tell you what they aren't. They're pretty safe that way. But they never, they won't disclose it.

I think there's two reasons for it. You've got to be slightly careful according to the monastic rule that you don't say what you're not if there's some ulterior motive, such as getting good support, finding a fan. So that would be a very serious mistake. And in fact, although you don't have to say it—there's no big confession, there's nothing—but in your heart of hearts, you'd know that you'd actually lost your robes. You're no longer in communion, as it's put. So there's always this tremendous wariness about talking about what you've achieved. And as I say, it's usually between you and the teacher.

In lay people, that would be the same if you were working with a monastic teacher. They won't even tell you sometimes. They won't even tell you whether you have or not. And this is on the understanding that if you have made a deep insight, you'll continue. I mean, that's the whole point of something like stream entry: that now the Dhamma gates are open. You've got to advance because you've seen the end of the path, even if it's only a flash. There's something in you now which knows which way to go.

Again, in the monastic life, you're not supposed to be alone in the forests, in the jungles, until you've achieved that, for the danger is of going mad, for heaven's sake. But these days it's become a common thing to talk about. There's a whole website where people talk about their relationship, about their experiences and what they've attained. And there's a danger there of overestimation and of achieving something that they have thought about, that they've imagined. And this is the big problem with knowing too much about it. It's alright if you know a lot about it, but the thing is to in a sense forget it, because whatever a spiritual insight is, it's not within our power. It's not within our willpower to attain it. In fact, that very willpower of trying to get this spiritual insight is going to be the biggest of all barriers.

This definitely happened with people whom I was involved with in those early days with my own teacher. I remember him at the end of a retreat going through all these *vipassanā* insights and then telling us to decide where we were, which is absolutely—for a Westerner, that's mortal danger. Either they underestimate themselves, which is good, and they keep working, or they completely overestimate themselves and they stop working. And if they find that they're not moving so much, they become very discouraged.

I often think back, I often think of all those people that I used to meditate with in those early days in the middle, early 80s. I don't think I've ever seen them again. They've all fled. There's only one person that I remember whom I occasionally meet up with from those days. So I don't know, maybe they've carried on, maybe not. But you can imagine if you set yourself a task and you take six months off a year—some people taking six months off a year, going to Japan to teach English to get a bit of money, and then coming back and do six months. And you do that year in, year out for five, six, seven years. And you're still in the same

place you were seven years ago. So there's a blowout. There's a complete lack of, there's a destruction of confidence and you just give up.

So these four stages of insight are to be taken as a path which we will all eventually make. And you can be a universalist at some point. Everybody has to go through it because everybody has this Buddha within. And this Buddha within in everybody is seeking liberation from suffering. But the paths leading to it are quite varied. This particular format only arises in the commentaries. There's nothing about this sort of stuff in any detail in the scriptures.

At the end of the discourse on how to establish right awareness, the Buddha says, "Well, if you do this properly, even within seven years, you can be fully liberated or become a non-returner." And then he says, "No, not seven years—seven months." And he says, "No, not seven months—seven weeks." He said, "If you do this really properly, even within seven days, you can be fully liberated or become a non-returner." Now you might think, "Oh, seven days, that's all right, I'll do a retreat." But he's talking about seven days where you don't lose your mindfulness. Oh, that's a different kettle of fish altogether. And it's got to be right awareness. You can't just wander about being aware.

So there's an inbuilt understanding that progress towards liberation is there within the system. But this stratifying of it in little *vipassanā* jhānas only comes up in the commentary, in the *Visuddhimagga*, the Path of Purification. It's in an earlier book, too, called The Path of Purity. Now, that suggests to me that all that was passed from teacher to student, teacher to student. It wasn't something that you spread out on the internet and created all sorts of ideas in people's minds.

So, having said that, just to give you the scope of it for those people especially who don't know about this: when one begins to meditate, you have to put some time away to develop the necessary concentration, the necessary stillness of mind and mindfulness. And when you do that, of course, you get the benefits. And they're called the defilements of *vipassanā*. You can suddenly feel tremendously peaceful, so peaceful that you've never felt before that you think, "Oh, this is *Nibbāna*." Suddenly you can become tremendously insightful in the Dhamma and want to write a book, because you've understood everything.

I had—he wasn't a student of mine, he used to come to Vihara—and he came back from a retreat at Amaravati and he said that he'd experienced *Nibbāna*. So I said to him, "What happened?" He said, "Well, I was sitting on the toilet and this amazing mental state came. I was completely blissed out." And I said, "Oh, but you were blissed out. There was a you and there was being blissed out." I said, "Well, that's not *Nibbāna*, is it?" And he said, "No, no, that's *Nibbāna*." He was absolutely convinced it was *Nibbāna*. He thought that in letting go of stuff, he was letting go of everything else. And this came, this blissed-out state, which he then presumed was *Nibbāna*, because that's what it says. It says the bliss of *Nibbāna*. So you can see, it's very easy to get things wrong and to overestimate because of the words, the descriptions that are used.

But one isn't caught up in that at all. And then one has an insight into impermanence. This is the classical way. Now that impermanence shakes a person because it sinks deep at some level that of their own

personal impermanence. So it's like coming face to face with death. And then there becomes what's known as these *dukkha ñāṇas*, the insights which are really to do with an emotional adjustment to that sort of insight. So the fear, the depression, very much like the things that you go through when you're told you've got only so much to live. It's the same sort of experience.

But you keep going and then there's another insight which, as it were, tells you the gate that you're going to go through, whether it's through the gate of impermanence, or the gate of suffering, or the gate of not-self. And you keep going, and one day, it pops, and then you've made it. And this popping, this process can take years. I met one man, he'd been working with it, and he said it took him five years to get through this.

What's always mysterious to me is that some people really are totally devoted to it, spend lots of time meditating. And apparently, from the outside, you can't understand why, but they're living a very moral, ethical life. They're devoting so much time to meditation, but nothing ever happens. So people are extremely particular and peculiar in their own little ways. So there's no way that you can write down this thing on a wall and say, "Right, I'll do this and then this will happen and this," because it just doesn't seem to work that way.

But one of the consequences of the stream entrant is that the view of self is broken. And that's not the same as the sense of self. And that's why often a person who has such an insight doesn't believe that it's been an insight at all because they still feel very much like an ego. They still feel very much me, about me. But something has cut through and undermined it. So there's a view of self and the sense of self. Now that sense of self doesn't go till you're fully liberated. That sense of self always attaches itself to some experience you're having. And that attachment doesn't go until the very end of the process. So it's not as though we're going to get rid of that sense of self very quickly.

And the other thing is that you're clear about the practice. So other ideas that you had, specifically around rites and rituals, you've often given them too much power. So for instance, somebody in Buddhism might think that what's really important is to light candles and to keep saying "I take refuge in the Buddha, I take refuge in the Dhamma," and by saying that somehow that's going to create liberation from suffering. So what happens is you begin to see rituals as something that supports—you don't have to get rid of them, but you disempower them. They're no longer really going to help you very much to liberate yourself from suffering.

And of course, the third one is that there's enough insight for a person to lose any doubt in the Buddha's teachings. So this opens the gate. This opens the gate much more to further practice. So you're not held back by: "Is this right for me? Is this teacher any good? Should I be doing this anyway?" All that's gone. Which doesn't mean to say that you might not change your teacher or find something else or become a Muslim, but at least the way's open.

As we carry on, there's further insight into one of those three characteristics. It's always the same:

impermanence, not-self, how we create suffering, the role of desire. It's always the same stuff. The practice at the beginning, when you're told how to sit, how to observe and what it is you're investigating, never changes. That's the wonderful thing. There's nothing more to learn. Once you've got it, that's it. That will take you right to the end.

Somebody comes on a course and they've done the opening gambit. Then they come to me and say, "Yeah, now what's the next step?" Well, the next step is this is it. You keep doing the same thing over and over and over again.

So on another insight, the only thing that really happens is a lessening of your attachment to sensual pleasure. And with it, of course, all those other things that run along with it. So we talked about them this morning: frustration when you don't get what you want—you're much more easy with change and stuff like that—depression when you really haven't got what you want, anxiety, a sense of loss, the boredom. All that's diminished because your relationship to seeking happiness in the sensual world has been attenuated. Some spice has been taken out of it.

But it's only when you get to a non-returner that you're finished with the sensual world as a place to seek happiness. It doesn't mean to say that you don't enjoy happiness, you don't enjoy things, it's just that you're no longer confusing that with something that is truly worthwhile. And that's why it's called a non-returner, because such a being is not drawn back into this physical form or into a sensual form, because they're done with it.

But they have usually—not always, don't have to—but usually they've developed very beautiful inner mental states that we call the absorptions. And they become attached to those things. So that has to go too eventually.

And the final ones are a sense of restlessness. Now, that restlessness, as I understand it, are just the remnants, the sort of what's left of all those bad habits we had. So there might be a touch, a little wave of anxiety or a wave of irritation, but they're no longer these huge things that we used to suffer from. So restlessness is a blanket term for a low-level state of impurity in the heart. And conceit. So remember there are three conceits.

I am better than, I'm worse than, which is often more comfortable, and I'm equal to. And the equal to often confuses us. But remember that when you gather around you all those people you're equal to, you'll find that they're either better than or worse than the other group. So it just feels a nicer conceit because you've got lots of friends. But it's still a conceit. It's still a comparison. So even that has to go.

And then finally, just that whole business of ignorance. And he gives us some images for it. He says people who have a first insight, it's like a flash of lightning. They've seen everything, but it's so quick that it's gone, you might say. But they've seen it as a flash of lightning. And the next one sees it like a full starry night where there's light and they can see, but it's not so. The non-returner is like a full moon, see? And

the full moon in the east is even brighter than here. I mean, there's colour, there's colour. But you don't get to see things as they really are, like the midday sun, until you become an Arahant.

Another nice image, which is not in the scripture, and I often wonder why, is the use of climbing a mountain. And I can only presume that the Buddha never climbed a mountain. This was a romantic thing, wasn't it? Nobody climbed mountains. What did he climb a mountain for? It was only when this love of nature came that one began to climb mountains or to see them as something that had to be conquered. So where he lived on that plain, the Gangetic plain, there were hills. But I mean, the mountains, the Himalayas were there. In fact, his people would have sat sort of in, well, a few days distance from them. But it never occurred to them to climb it, I think. Why would you go up a mountain? So I don't think, my feeling is he never uses that image.

But if you think about it, when you start off climbing a hill, what are you looking at? It's just a bit of grass, isn't it? A bit of grass, dirt in front of you. I mean, there's no joy in it at all. You're presuming that you'll get to a point where you'll turn around and have a vista, and that's going to be enjoyable. So off you go, and after a while you get a bit tired, and you think, well, I'll take a rest. And you turn around, and oh, it's just a lovely view, you see. Now, if you stay there too long, you tend to come back down for a cup of tea, right? But before you get cold, you think, well, better get up again. So off you go and you go a bit further and the scene gets broader. And so it is all the way up. But you never get the 360 degree view until you're right at the top. There's always a piece of dirt in front of you and what's on the other side of the mountain. So I always think that's a good image as to what we're trying to do here.

So that whole business of the insights and all that, you can read about them. There's lots of stuff now on the website about them, and lots of people describing them. But I think there's a danger in that, because you can't help but have some idea. And you're sat there, and for instance, you're feeling, suddenly you're feeling all this bubblyness, and you think, oh yeah, that's the *vipassanā* kilesa. That's the... And then something flashes across your mind and you say, oh, that's impermanence. I must be a sort of planner now. So if I, my general, my advice is, by all means, read about them, then forget about them.

And I think we're on much surer ground when we are actually practising to purify the heart. That will never disappoint us. The more that we purify the heart, the more we find life to be more beautiful, more enjoyable. And in fact, you could say that the Buddha equates happiness with virtue. I mean, in the discourse on the Mangala Sutta, the discourse on blessings, it's all about being virtuous. So it's not about owning things or doing this or doing that. So it's just about looking after people, having a job which is, from your point of view, a service to society, and developing virtues. And this, he says, are the highest blessings.

So if we move that way, at least we can often tell that there's been some movement within us as these defilements begin to lessen their hold on us. And that means that the defilement itself has lost power. So I always think that's a better approach.

I was going to go on to other stuff, but I think I'm... Oh, yes, I have. I've gone over time. Very good. So unless there are immediate questions arising from that... Fantastic. We can take a break.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not created even greater confusion, and that by your practice you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Transcriptions produced locally using Swiss low-carbon electricity. Corrections and rewriting by cloud-hosted AI.